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Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1950-1961

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Place Coverage: Nyae Nyae Region, Namibia And Botswana

Section Title(S): POLYGYNOUS MARRIAGE

The number of wives a man may have simultaneously is not limited by social rule. However, despite many men's saying they would like to have more wives, most had only one. There is no great excess of women in the population and in this egalitarian society in which all possessions are carried by the owners and in which possessions pass from one to another in a stream of gift-giving, no man has appreciably more wealth than another to give him advantage. Nor does any man have status which entitles him to special privileges in obtaining wives. An agreeable personality and the ability to hunt are to a man's advantage. The determining factor in the contracting of polygynous marriages, however, is the feelings of the man and woman who marry.

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At the time we were in the field only nine men in a sample of eighty-eight had two wives; none had more than two. However, we heard of one man, /Ti!kay's father, then dead, who had four, and /Qui's father had had three.

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Marriage to the same man gives co-wives the joking relationship, and they do not observe the sitting or the name avoidance, though they may have observed those avoidances and may have avoided joking before marriage. Co-wives apply the kin terms *!kwi* or *tsĩ* (sister) to each other, or, if they have the same name, they apply the terms *!gun!a* and *!guma*. Megan Biesele has given me another term that is used by cowives for each other and is also used in reference to co-wives, *!gwa' di*.

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The !Kung, though they do not institutionalize the sororate, say it is a good idea to marry sisters because they are not so likely to be jealous of each other as other women are. Of the nine pairs of co-wives we knew, three pairs were sisters, another was a pair of half sisters.² None of the others had traceable consanguineous ties. The !Kung's claim that sisters tended to have more harmonious relations than other pairs of co-wives seemed to be confirmed by any observations we could make. The two attractive sisters who were /Ti!kay's wives appeared to have a particularly close, harmonious relationship. I thought it never more apparent than 264 when they lay down to sleep, /Ti!kay in the middle, a wife on each side, on cold nights both very close to him.

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2. In the paper previously published, I wrote that only two of the nine pairs of co-wives had traceable consanguineous ties. Further work in my notes brought two more pairs to my attention.

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